

H2 Economics (9570)

Crafting Evaluation Paragraphs

A Step-by-Step Guide for 8-Mark and 10-Mark CSQ Questions

Using the SPECIES Evaluation Framework

Also covers: H1 vs H2 distinctions • SEAB mark-scheme language (L1/L2/L3 + E1/E2/E3)
Sentence-starter bank • SEAB-format worked examples • SPECIES by topic (all 13 topics)

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Chapter 1 Why Evaluation Matters

In H2 Economics CSQ Paper 1, the 8-mark and 10-mark questions are where you win or lose your grade. These questions test **Assessment Objective 4 (AO4)**: the ability to evaluate economic arguments, weigh evidence, and reach a reasoned judgement. Two students who know the same theory will be separated by who can evaluate and conclude.

The most common mistake is writing a one-sided answer (all thesis, no antithesis) or presenting both sides without weighing them (no evaluation). Both approaches **cap your marks**.

Section A — H1 vs H2: Key Differences Under AO4

Feature	H1 (8843)	H2 (9570)
Syllabus paper with evaluation	Paper 1 only (CSQ, 100% of grade)	Paper 1 (CSQ, 40%) + Paper 2 (Essays, 60%)
AO4 definition	Identical to H2	Identical to H1
Mark-scheme grid	L1/L2/L3 + E1/E2	L1/L2/L3 + E1/E2/E3
Expected evaluation depth	Balanced two-sided argument + substantiated judgement	Same, plus: challenge model assumptions; advanced synthesis
Content scope	No Market Structure; limited international trade	Full scope: Market Structure, Marshall-Lerner, game theory
HOT mark allocation per case study	~24 marks of 40	~18 marks of 30

Section B — Mark Allocation: Where Do Evaluation Marks Come From?

Component	8-mark	10-mark	What the examiner looks for
Introduction	1 mark	1 mark	Define the key term. State the context briefly.
Thesis (FOR)	2–3 marks	3–4 marks	2–3 well-developed arguments. Causal chains + extract evidence.
Antithesis (AGAINST)	2–3 marks	3–4 marks	2–3 counter-arguments directly challenging the thesis. Not unrelated points.
Evaluation + Judgement	2–3 marks	2–3 marks	SPECIES criteria to weigh thesis vs antithesis. A clear, substantiated judgement.

Key Insight: Without any evaluation, you lose 2–3 marks entirely and are capped at L2 KAA regardless of how strong the analysis is. The difference between an 8-mark and a 10-mark answer is more developed thesis and antithesis — the SPECIES + judgement structure is the same for both.



Chapter 2 SEAB Mark-Scheme Language: L1/L2/L3 + E1/E2/E3

SEAB does not publish mark schemes publicly. However, JC internal prelim mark schemes (RI, VJC, HCI, ACJC, TJC) converge on the level descriptors below. Understanding these helps you self-diagnose your own scripts.

Section A — KAA Bands (8-Mark / 10-Mark ‘Discuss’ Questions)

Band	Label	What the examiner sees
L3	Well-balanced, two-sided	A well-balanced answer with good scope and rigour. Two-sided discussion with reference to case evidence and sufficient reasoned judgement. Diagrams accurately drawn and used.
L2	Underdeveloped or one-sided	Underdeveloped two-sided discussion lacking judgement, OR a developed explanation of only one side. Some case evidence used.
L1	Descriptive / irrelevant	Descriptive response with some knowledge. Mostly irrelevant, or glaring conceptual errors, or one-sided with no case evidence.

Section B — Evaluation Bands

Band	Available in	What it means and how to achieve it
E3	10-mark only	Well-developed evaluative judgements across both sides, backed by sound economic analysis. Judgement is synthesised, not merely summarised. Includes explicit SR vs LR considerations and context from the case extract.
E2	8m and 10m	Judgement explained AND anchored in economic analysis. Goes beyond a summary of earlier points. Includes at least one evaluative qualifier: magnitude, elasticity, time period, or stakeholder impact.
E1	8m and 10m	An unexplained evaluative statement. Makes a stand with no or minimal substantiation. Judgement is a restatement or summary of earlier points.
E0	All questions	No evaluation. Answer capped at L2 KAA regardless of analysis strength.

The key move — E1 to E2/E3: ‘Summary/stand without reasons’ → ‘explicit judgement substantiated with economic analysis, anchored in case context, ideally adding SR/LR or magnitude/elasticity nuance.’

Section C — Self-Marking Checklist (Use Before Submitting)

- Is my answer two-sided? (If no → L2 cap regardless of quality)
- Does my antithesis directly challenge my thesis? (If it is a different topic → deduct KAA marks)
- Have I quoted or paraphrased at least one piece of case evidence in my thesis AND antithesis?
- Have I written an explicit evaluation paragraph using SPECIES? (If no → E0, losing 2–3 marks)
- Does my judgement go beyond a summary? Does it state which side is stronger AND explain why?
- Have I named at least one condition that would change my conclusion?



Chapter 3 Overall Answer Structure

Section A — 8-Mark Answer: Recommended Structure (12 Minutes Total)

Step	Think — your planning	Write — on your answer script
Step 1	What is the question asking? What key term needs defining?	Introduction (1–2 sentences): Define the key term. State the context from the extract.
Step 2	What are 2 arguments FOR?	Thesis: Present 2 well-developed points. Each = concept + causal chain + extract evidence.
Step 3	What are 2 arguments AGAINST?	Antithesis: Present 2 counter-arguments. Each must directly challenge a thesis point.
Step 4	Which side is stronger? What conditions matter?	Evaluation paragraph: Apply 2–3 SPECIES criteria. State which side is stronger and why.
Step 5	What is my overall position?	Judgement (1–2 sentences): A clear, substantiated conclusion. Not a restatement of the question.

Section B — 10-Mark Answer: Recommended Structure (15 Minutes Total)

Step	Think — your planning	Write — on your answer script
Step 1	Same as 8-mark.	Introduction: Define + context.
Step 2	What are 2–3 arguments FOR?	Thesis: Present 2–3 well-developed points. More depth per point than 8m. Use more extract evidence.
Step 3	What are 2–3 arguments AGAINST?	Antithesis: Present 2–3 counter-arguments. More depth per point than 8m.
Step 4	Same as 8-mark but with fuller application.	Evaluation paragraph: Apply 3–4 SPECIES criteria. Weigh with explicit reference to context.
Step 5	Same as 8-mark.	Judgement: Clear, substantiated conclusion with conditions stated.

Time Budget: 8-mark = 12 minutes (2 min plan, 10 min write). 10-mark = 15 minutes (3 min plan, 12 min write). Spend at least 3–4 minutes on Steps 4–5. A common exam failure is running out of time on the final 10-mark question — you lose all 3 evaluation marks at once.



Chapter 4 Step 1 — Read the Stem: What Type of Evaluation?

Before planning your answer, identify what the question stem is asking you to evaluate. **Misreading the stem is the single most costly mistake.**

Section A — Core Stems

Stem	The question is asking...	Your evaluation must...	Your judgement must end with...
Discuss whether...	Is the stated proposition true or false?	Weigh evidence for and against the proposition	A clear yes/no position with reasoning
Assess the effectiveness...	Does the stated policy achieve its objective?	Evaluate: constraints → effectiveness → feasibility	Whether the policy is effective and under what conditions
To what extent...	How much is the stated claim true?	Assess the degree to which the claim holds	“To a [large/moderate/limited] extent because...”
Evaluate whether [X] is the best...	Is X better than alternatives?	Compare X against at least one alternative on the same criteria	Which approach is better and why
Discuss the consequences...	What happens as a result?	Weigh positive consequences against negative, considering stakeholders	Whether the net effect is positive or negative overall

Section B — Additional Stems (Firms and International Economics)

Stem	Your evaluation must...	Your judgement must end with...
Discuss whether consumers benefit from [firm strategy/market structure]	Weigh impact on price (CS), quality, variety, and innovation. Use the three-efficiency framework: allocative, productive, and dynamic.	Whether consumers benefit on balance, and under what conditions (competition level, time horizon, regulation).
Discuss the benefits and costs of [globalisation/FDI/trade] for [economy]	Weigh AD/AS benefits, employment, technology transfer vs structural unemployment, inequality, external vulnerability. Assess by stakeholder.	Whether benefits outweigh costs overall, and what domestic policies mitigate costs.
Discuss whether [country] should pursue trade liberalisation/protectionism	Compare free trade benefits against protectionism arguments. Apply to the specific economy's context.	Whether the economy is better served by liberalisation or protection, given its stage of development.
Discuss whether [tariff/quota] is justified	Use tariff diagram welfare analysis (CS loss, PS gain, DWL). Then apply SPECIES: infant industry validity, retaliation risk, less distortionary alternatives.	Whether the measure is justified given welfare costs and availability of alternatives.



Chapter 5 Step 2 — Writing the Thesis and Antithesis

Each thesis and antithesis point must follow a four-part structure. Listing points without development earns minimal marks.

Section A — The Four-Part Structure for Each Point

Part	What it does	Example — ‘Assess the effectiveness of a carbon tax’
1. State the argument	A clear topic sentence making the claim	“The tax is effective in reducing carbon emissions.”
2. Explain the mechanism	The economic causal chain: concept → effect	“The tax raises MPC, shifting the supply curve leftward. Market price rises, quantity demanded falls. Output moves from Q_e toward Q_s where $MSB = MSC$.”
3. Apply to context	Reference extract data or Singapore-specific detail	“Extract 2 states that carbon emissions from the manufacturing sector fell 8% in the year following the tax increase, consistent with this analysis.”
4. Link back to the question	Explicitly state what this means for the proposition	“This demonstrates that the carbon tax is effective in moving output toward the socially optimal level and reducing the negative externality in production.”

Common mistake: Writing the antithesis as an unrelated second topic rather than a direct challenge to the thesis. If your thesis says ‘the tax is effective’, your antithesis must explain why the tax may NOT be effective — not switch to a different policy. The examiner cannot award L3 KAA if your two sides do not engage with the same proposition.

Section B — Using Case Extract Evidence (SEAB Requirement)

CSQ questions require extract reference. Pure theory without application loses KAA marks.

- **Paraphrase:** “Extract 2 (paragraph 3) indicates that...”
- **Direct quote (keep short):** “According to Extract 1, [short phrase]...”
- **Data reference:** “The data in Figure 1 shows that [variable] rose by [x]%. . .”
- **Always:** explain what the evidence means for your argument — do not leave the citation unlinked.



Chapter 6 Step 3 — The Evaluation Paragraph: SPECIES Framework

This is the step that separates L3 answers from L2. After presenting thesis and antithesis, you must weigh them using specific evaluation criteria. **Pick 2–3 most relevant to the question** — do not try to use all seven.

Section A — The Seven SPECIES Criteria

	Criterion	The question it answers	How to write the evaluation sentence	When to prioritise
S	Short-run vs Long-run	Does the conclusion change depending on the time horizon?	“In the short run, [thesis holds] because [reason]. However, in the long run, [antithesis becomes stronger] because [reason].”	Almost always relevant for policy questions.
P	Priorities of government	Which objective is the government prioritising?	“The effectiveness depends on the government’s priorities. If the priority is [X], then [thesis]. But if [Y], then [antithesis].”	When the question involves policy trade-offs or multiple objectives.
E	Extent of the problem	How severe is the issue? Does severity affect which side is stronger?	“If [the issue is severe], [thesis holds] because [reason]. If [the issue is mild], [antithesis holds].”	When the question asks whether a response is appropriate or proportionate.
C	Cost (fiscal/opportunity)	What is the fiscal cost? What is forgone?	“The S\$[X] spent on [policy] could have been used for [alternative], which may yield greater societal welfare.”	When evaluating government spending, subsidies, or direct provision.
I	Impact on stakeholders	Who benefits and who is harmed?	“While [stakeholder A] benefits, [stakeholder B] is adversely affected because [reason]. The net welfare effect depends on the relative magnitude.”	When the question involves consequences for different groups.
E	Efficacy of alternatives	Would a different policy work better?	“An alternative — [alternative policy] — may be more effective because [reason]. However, it also has limitations: [limitation].”	When the stem says ‘best’ or ‘most effective’.
S	Side-effects / unintended consequences	Does the policy cause unintended harm?	“However, the policy may have unintended consequences. [Side-effect] may undermine the intended outcome, reducing its overall effectiveness.”	Almost always relevant.

Section B — The Three-Layer Evaluation Sequence (Policy Questions)



Layer	Question to ask	What to write	SPECIES
1. Constraints	Can the policy even be used?	“First, the policy may face constraints in implementation. [E.g. the government lacks accurate information / the country lacks fiscal space / political constraints prevent adoption].”	C, P
2. Effectiveness	If implemented, does it achieve the intended objective?	“Even if implemented, the policy may not be fully effective because [e.g. demand is price-inelastic, so the tax reduces quantity by only a small amount / the multiplier is small in an open economy].”	S, E
3. Feasibility	Does it cause side-effects that outweigh the benefits?	“Furthermore, the policy may cause unintended consequences. [E.g. a tax on cigarettes is regressive — it disproportionately burdens low-income households / exchange rate appreciation hurts export-oriented firms].”	S, I

After the three layers, conclude: “On balance, the policy is [effective/partially effective/ineffective] because [the dominant layer]. A combination of [policies] is likely most appropriate.”



Section C — SPECIES Applied Across Domains (Quick Reference)

Criterion	Micro Policy	Macro Policy	Firms	International
S — SR vs LR	PED becomes more elastic over time; tax more effective in LR.	Fiscal has implementation lags. Multiplier operates over successive rounds.	Market power harms consumers in SR but may fund R&D in LR.	J-curve: depreciation worsens trade balance in SR before improving it in LR.
P — Priorities	Efficiency vs equity? Tax is efficient but may be regressive.	Growth, inflation, employment, or trade balance?	Consumer welfare or industrial competitiveness?	Domestic employment (protectionism) or consumer welfare (free trade)?
E — Extent	How large is the externality? Small MEC may not justify intervention.	How deep is the recession? Mild vs severe.	How much market power? Near-monopoly vs loose oligopoly.	How dependent is the economy on trade? Singapore (trade-to-GDP 300%+) vs large domestic economy.
C — Cost	Opportunity cost of subsidy. Fiscal burden of direct provision.	Fiscal sustainability. Budget deficit. Crowding out.	Cost of regulation and enforcement vs welfare gain.	Cost of protectionism: higher consumer prices, DWL, potential retaliation.
I — Impact	Consumers vs producers vs third parties.	Exporters vs domestic consumers.	Consumers (price, choice) vs the firm (profits) vs rival firms.	Domestic workers in protected industries vs consumers vs foreign trade partners.
E — Alternatives	Tax vs subsidy vs regulation vs education.	Fiscal vs monetary vs supply-side vs exchange rate.	Competition policy vs trade liberalisation vs price regulation.	Tariff vs quota vs subsidy to domestic industry vs retraining.
S — Side-effects	Black markets from bans. Moral hazard from subsidies.	Fiscal expansion may cause inflation. Appreciation may cause structural UE in export sectors.	Regulation may stifle innovation. Breaking up monopolies may lose EOS.	Free trade may cause structural unemployment. FDI may lead to profit repatriation.

Section D — Evaluating Policy Conflicts (H2 Required)



Conflict	Why they conflict	How to write the evaluation
Growth vs Inflation	Expansionary policy to boost growth ($AD\uparrow$) may cause demand-pull inflation if the economy is near full employment.	“However, the fiscal expansion may conflict with price stability. If the economy is already near full employment, the rise in AD will be largely inflationary rather than output-expanding.”
Growth vs Trade Balance	Higher growth raises income, increasing import demand ($M\uparrow$), worsening the trade balance.	“The growth may come at the cost of a worsening trade balance, as higher income increases demand for imports. This is particularly significant for Singapore, where imports constitute a large share of consumption.”
Low UE vs Inflation	Reducing unemployment through AD expansion may cause demand-pull inflation as the economy nears capacity.	“While the policy reduces cyclical unemployment, the tight labour market may push up wages, contributing to cost-push inflation. The government faces a trade-off between employment and price stability.”
Growth vs Equity	Growth may disproportionately benefit high-income earners, worsening inequality.	“The growth strategy may worsen income inequality if the benefits accrue primarily to high-skilled, high-income workers. Without complementary redistributive policies, growth may not be inclusive.”
Price Stability vs Competitiveness	Exchange rate appreciation to control inflation makes exports more expensive.	“MAS’s SGD appreciation reduces imported inflation but reduces export competitiveness. Export-oriented firms face lower revenue and may reduce output and employment.”



Section E — Three-Efficiency Framework for Firms Questions

Use this structure when the question asks ‘Discuss whether consumers benefit’ or ‘Assess the impact on efficiency’ in the context of firms.

Efficiency type	Thesis — market power HARMS	Antithesis — market power BENEFITS	How to evaluate
Allocative efficiency ($P = MC$)	Firm with market power sets $P > MC$. Underproduction. DWL. Consumers pay higher prices.	If the firm achieves significant EOS, prices may still be lower than under perfect competition (natural monopoly argument).	“Whether allocative inefficiency results depends on the extent of market power and whether EOS offset the price mark-up.”
Productive efficiency (min AC)	Without competitive pressure, the firm may become complacent (X-inefficiency). Costs remain above minimum AC.	Potential competition (contestable markets) may discipline the firm. Large firms can achieve lower LRAC through EOS.	“Whether productive inefficiency occurs depends on barriers to entry and the threat of potential competition.”
Dynamic efficiency (R&D)	If the firm faces no competitive threat, it has little incentive to innovate.	Supernormal profits fund R&D and innovation, improving products and lowering costs over time.	“There is a trade-off between allocative efficiency (SR consumer harm) and dynamic efficiency (LR consumer benefit). The net effect depends on whether the firm reinvests its supernormal profits.”

After assessing all three efficiency types, conclude: “On balance, consumers [benefit/are harmed] because [the dominant efficiency effect]. Effective government regulation (e.g. CCCS in Singapore) can preserve the benefits of dynamic efficiency while limiting allocative harm.”



Chapter 7 Step 4 — The Judgement: How to Conclude

The judgement is the final 1–3 sentences of your answer. It must be **substantiated** — meaning it states a clear position and explains why that position is more convincing than the alternative. A vague conclusion (‘it depends’) without reasoning earns **zero evaluation marks**.

Section A — Judgement Templates by Stem Type

Discuss whether...

Template: “On balance, [the proposition is true/false] because [dominant reason from evaluation]. This conclusion holds more strongly when [condition], but less strongly when [opposite condition].”

Example: “On balance, the carbon tax is partially effective in reducing emissions because the 8% fall in manufacturing emissions demonstrates responsiveness to price. This holds more strongly in the long run as firms invest in cleaner technology, but less strongly for industries with few low-carbon substitutes where demand is price-inelastic.”

To what extent...

Template: “To a [large/moderate/limited] extent, [conclusion] because [dominant reason]. However, [qualifying factor] limits the extent to which this conclusion holds.”

Example: “To a moderate extent, the subsidy has corrected the under-consumption of education because enrolment rose by 15%. However, information failure persists — many households remain unaware of the full private benefits, limiting the subsidy’s reach.”

Assess effectiveness...

Template: “The policy is [effective/partially effective/ineffective] in achieving [stated objective] because [dominant reason]. Its effectiveness is [enhanced/limited] by [condition]. A more comprehensive approach combining [policy A] and [policy B] would be more effective.”

Example: “MAS’s SGD appreciation is effective in reducing imported inflation because cheaper imports lower both consumer prices and production costs. Its effectiveness is limited during global supply shocks. Combining exchange rate policy with targeted fiscal support (GST vouchers) would be more effective.”

Evaluate whether [X] is the best...

Template: “[X] is [the best/not the best] approach because [reason]. While [alternative Y] has the advantage of [strength], it is limited by [weakness]. [X] is more suitable when [condition], while [Y] is more suitable when [other condition].”

Example: “Direct provision is not necessarily the best approach because it imposes a large fiscal burden and may stifle innovation. Subsidies preserve consumer choice and are more cost-effective. However, direct provision is more suitable for essential services where universal access is the priority, such as primary education.”

Discuss consequences...

Template: “The net consequence is [positive/negative/ambiguous] because [the dominant effect]. While [positive consequence] benefits [stakeholder], [negative consequence] harms [other stakeholder]. The overall impact depends on [stated condition].”

Example: “The net consequence of globalisation for Singapore is positive because access to larger export markets and cheaper inputs raises both AD and AS. While structural unemployment harms low-skilled workers, this is mitigated by SkillsFuture retraining. The overall impact depends on the government’s ability to manage distributional costs.”



Chapter 8 Sentence-Starter Bank

Memorise 3–4 sentence starters per topic. These signal to the examiner that you are making an evaluative move, not merely continuing your analysis.

Section A — Magnitude

- “The magnitude of [variable] depends on...”
- “The shift in AD/AS is unlikely to be significant given that...”
- “Even if [policy] is implemented, the effect is small because [PED/MPC/multiplier value]...”

Section B — Elasticity

- “Given that the demand is price-inelastic ($PED \approx \dots$ from Extract X), the tax will raise revenue but have limited effect on quantity demanded...”
- “The effectiveness of the tax depends on whether $PED > 1$ or < 1 . Extract X suggests PED is [value], implying...”

Section C — Time Period

- “In the short run, [thesis holds] because firms/consumers lack time to adjust. However, in the long run, [antithesis], as [adjustment mechanism].”
- “Fiscal policy has an implementation lag of [X months], meaning the stimulus may only reach the economy when [condition has changed].”

Section D — Challenging Assumptions (H2 — Higher Difficulty)

- “This argument assumes rational consumers / ceteris paribus / perfect information. In reality, [deviation from assumption], which means [effect on conclusion].”
- “The Keynesian multiplier analysis assumes no crowding out. However, in Singapore’s open economy with high capital mobility, government borrowing may raise interest rates and crowd out private investment.”
- “The Marshall-Lerner condition assumes that the sum of PED for exports and imports exceeds 1. Whether this holds for Singapore depends on [factor].”

Section E — Stakeholder Impact

- “Consumers will benefit from [policy] because [reason], but producers will be worse off because [reason]. On balance, [dominant group] is more significantly affected because [reason].”
- “The distributional impact is uneven: [stakeholder A] gains [type of gain], while [stakeholder B] loses [type of loss]. Whether this is acceptable depends on the government’s equity objectives.”

Section F — Constraints and Root Cause

- “Since the underlying cause of [unemployment/inflation] is structural / cost-push, demand-side policies will be of limited effectiveness in addressing the root cause.”



- “Singapore’s small and open economy means that fiscal multipliers are reduced by high import leakages and CPF savings, limiting the impact of expansionary fiscal policy on national income.”
- “The government may lack the accurate information needed to set the corrective tax/subsidy at the precise MEC/MEB level.”

Section G — Singapore-Specific Context Hooks

- “MAS uses a managed exchange rate (not interest rates) as the primary monetary policy tool. This means [implication for the policy being evaluated].”
- “Singapore’s trade-to-GDP ratio exceeds 300%, meaning [implication for multiplier / import leakages / external vulnerability].”
- “SkillsFuture and Workfare represent Singapore’s supply-side and redistributive responses to [structural unemployment / inequality from globalisation].”
- “COE and ERP demonstrate Singapore’s use of price-based instruments to address negative externalities from congestion.”

Section H — Synthesis and Stand-Substantiation

- “On balance, given the data in Extract X showing [evidence], [stand]. This is because [substantiation].”
- “On balance, [policy] is [effective/partially effective/ineffective] because [dominant reason]. The conclusion holds more strongly when [condition], but less strongly when [opposite condition].”
- “The weight of evidence suggests that [thesis/antithesis] is stronger, primarily because [dominant SPECIES criterion]. However, a combination of [policy A] and [policy B] is likely to be more effective than either alone.”



Chapter 9 Common Mistakes That Lose Evaluation Marks

Mistake	Why it loses marks	How to fix it
One-sided answer (all thesis, no antithesis)	Caps at L2. The examiner cannot award AO4 marks without both sides.	Always present at least 2 counter-arguments that directly challenge your thesis.
Both sides presented but no weighing	This is description, not evaluation. The examiner sees two lists but no judgement.	After both sides, write an explicit evaluation paragraph using SPECIES. State which side is stronger and why.
“It depends on many factors” — vague conclusion	E1 at best. This says nothing. No substantiation.	“On balance, X because Y. This holds when Z but not when W.”
Evaluation left until the end, then running out of time	You lose all evaluation marks at once.	Embed mini-evaluations within each thesis/antithesis point. Then add a final evaluation paragraph.
Antithesis is a different topic, not a counter to the thesis	You are listing, not evaluating. If your thesis discusses demand factors and your antithesis discusses supply factors as separate explanations, you have not engaged with the proposition.	Your antithesis must explain why the thesis argument is weakened, limited, or wrong. It must engage with the same proposition.
No extract evidence in thesis or antithesis	Loses KAA marks. Pure theory without application is penalised in CSQ questions.	Quote or paraphrase at least one piece of extract data in your thesis and one in your antithesis.
Copying the question stem as the conclusion	Not a judgement. “The tax may or may not be effective” earns E0.	Take a position. State which side you find more convincing and explain why based on your evaluation.
Using all 7 SPECIES criteria (checklist approach)	Produces shallow, rushed evaluation. Quality beats quantity.	Pick the 2–3 criteria most relevant to the question. Develop each fully rather than mentioning all superficially.
Treating H1 and H2 evaluation as different skills	The AO4 definition is identical for both syllabuses. H2 only adds breadth of content and the expectation of assumption-challenging moves at the top band.	Master the same SPECIES + Thesis–Antithesis–Evaluation–Judgement structure for both. Add assumption-challenging (FILTER-type) moves for H2 top-band answers.



Chapter 10 Worked Examples

All three examples mirror the SEAB CSQ format: each question is preceded by a mock extract, and every thesis, antithesis, and judgement paragraph cites the extract directly, as required by the mark scheme.

Example 1 — Micro Policy (10 Marks): Carbon Tax and Negative Externalities

Extract A (adapted)

Singapore's carbon tax, introduced at S\$5/tonne in 2019 and raised to S\$25/tonne in 2024, aims to correct the market failure caused by negative externalities in production. The Ministry of Sustainability and the Environment reported an 8% fall in carbon emissions from the manufacturing sector in the year following the 2024 increase. However, energy-intensive industries have raised concerns about competitiveness, and environmental groups argue that the tax remains below the true social cost of carbon.

Question: 'Assess the effectiveness of Singapore's carbon tax in correcting the market failure caused by negative externalities in production.' [10]

Step 1: Introduction

A negative externality in production occurs when the production process imposes costs on third parties not reflected in the market price, such that MSC exceeds MPC. The carbon tax is a market-based policy that aims to internalise this external cost by raising the private cost of production.

Step 2: Thesis — The carbon tax IS effective

First, the tax — set equal to MEC at the socially optimal output Q_s — raises MPC, shifting the supply curve leftward from S to S+tax. The market price rises, quantity demanded falls, and output moves from Q_e toward Q_s where MSB = MSC. The over-allocation of resources is corrected and deadweight loss is eliminated. This is consistent with Extract A, which shows that manufacturing emissions fell 8% following the 2024 tax increase, suggesting that firms and consumers are responsive to price signals.

Second, unlike command-and-control policies such as bans or quotas, the carbon tax works through the price mechanism and preserves producer choice. Firms may choose to pay the tax, invest in cleaner technology, or pass costs on to consumers. This incentivises innovation in low-carbon production, potentially achieving abatement at the lowest social cost.

Step 3: Antithesis — The carbon tax may NOT be effective

However, the government may lack accurate information to set the tax at the correct MEC level. As Extract A notes, environmental groups argue that the tax remains below the true social cost of carbon. If the tax is set below MEC, it fails to move output fully to Q_s , leaving a residual deadweight loss.

Furthermore, if demand for the goods produced using carbon-intensive methods is price-inelastic, the tax will raise prices but not significantly reduce quantity produced. Energy-intensive industries facing few low-carbon substitutes will simply pass the cost on to consumers. Extract A confirms that energy-intensive industries have raised concerns about competitiveness, suggesting limited substitutability in the short run.

The carbon tax may also be regressive. Higher energy prices disproportionately burden low-income households, which spend a larger share of income on energy and transport. This worsens income inequality unless the tax revenue is used to fund targeted transfers.

Step 4: Evaluation (SPECIES)

In the **short run** (S), the tax may not significantly reduce emissions because firms and consumers are slow to adjust behaviour and find alternatives. However, in the long run, the tax incentivises innovation in clean technology, raising its effectiveness over time. The **extent of the problem** (E) also matters: if emissions are causing severe, irreversible environmental damage, even an imperfect tax that partially corrects the market failure yields a net welfare gain. Regarding the **efficacy of alternatives** (E), tradeable pollution permits may more precisely target a specific quantity of emissions, but are costlier to administer and subject to price volatility. The **side-effects** (S) of



regressive impact can be mitigated through targeted transfers to low-income households funded by carbon tax revenue, but this adds fiscal cost.

Step 5: Judgement

On balance, the carbon tax is **partially effective** in correcting the negative externality in production. The 8% fall in manufacturing emissions following the 2024 tax increase (Extract A) confirms that price signals do influence behaviour. Its effectiveness is greatest in the long run when firms have time to invest in low-carbon technology, and when complemented by targeted transfers to address regressivity and by public information to address information failure. A policy mix of carbon tax, direct regulation, and targeted support is likely more effective than any single instrument alone.



Example 2 — Macro Policy (8 Marks): Fiscal Policy and Unemployment in Singapore

Extract B (adapted)

Singapore's GDP contracted by 5.4% in 2020 as global demand collapsed during the COVID-19 pandemic. The government deployed S\$100 billion in fiscal support over three budgets, including the Jobs Support Scheme (JSS), which subsidised employer wages in the most severely affected industries. The Ministry of Manpower reported that unemployment rose from 2.3% in 2019 to a peak of 3.5% in Q3 2020, before falling back to 2.1% by end-2021. Economists have noted that Singapore's fiscal multiplier is estimated at 0.5–0.7, significantly lower than in larger, less open economies.

Question: 'Discuss the effectiveness of fiscal policy in reducing demand-deficient unemployment in Singapore.' [8]

Step 1: Introduction

Demand-deficient unemployment occurs when AD falls during a recession, reducing output below full employment. Fiscal policy involves the use of government spending (G) and taxation (T) to influence AD.

Step 2: Thesis — Fiscal policy IS effective

Expansionary fiscal policy directly raises AD through increased G. The increase in G has a multiplied effect on national income, creating successive rounds of spending that raise output and employment beyond the initial injection. Crucially, fiscal policy can be targeted at the worst-affected sectors. The JSS in Extract B directly subsidised wages in the most severely impacted industries, preserving employment that would otherwise have been lost. Extract B shows that despite a 5.4% GDP contraction, unemployment peaked at only 3.5% and recovered to 2.1% by end-2021 — significantly better than trajectories observed in comparable recessions without fiscal intervention.

Step 3: Antithesis — Fiscal policy may NOT be effective

However, Singapore's fiscal multiplier is estimated at 0.5–0.7 (Extract B), significantly lower than in larger, less open economies. This is because each round of spending leaks heavily through high import demand (trade-to-GDP exceeds 300%), CPF contributions (reducing MPC), and moderate taxation. Furthermore, fiscal policy faces time lags — by the time spending reaches the economy, the recession may have deepened or recovered. If unemployment is structural rather than demand-deficient, fiscal expansion addresses the symptom (low AD) but not the root cause (skills mismatch).

Step 4: Evaluation (SPECIES)

The effectiveness depends on the **time horizon** (S): fiscal policy is a short-run demand management tool and cannot build long-term productive capacity. The **extent of the problem** (E) matters significantly: during the severe acute shock of COVID-19 (a 5.4% GDP contraction per Extract B), even a multiplier of 0.5–0.7 justifies large fiscal deployment. An **alternative** (E) — supply-side policies such as SkillsFuture retraining — addresses structural unemployment but takes years to take effect and cannot relieve immediate cyclical distress. A **policy conflict** (P) arises between growth and price stability: rapid fiscal expansion may contribute to demand-pull inflation if the economy recovers quickly and supply cannot keep pace.

Step 5: Judgement

On balance, fiscal policy is **partially effective** in reducing demand-deficient unemployment in Singapore. The data in Extract B — unemployment peaking at 3.5% despite a 5.4% GDP contraction — suggests that targeted fiscal measures such as the JSS successfully preserved employment during the acute phase of the recession. However, its impact is limited by the small multiplier (0.5–0.7) inherent in Singapore's small and open economy. A combination of targeted fiscal measures in the short run and supply-side retraining in the long run is most appropriate.



Example 3 — International Economics (10 Marks): Does Singapore Benefit from Globalisation?

Extract C (adapted)

Singapore's trade-to-GDP ratio exceeds 300%, making it one of the most globalised economies in the world. Real GDP per capita rose from approximately US\$12,000 in 1990 to over US\$65,000 by 2023, partly attributable to access to global export markets and FDI inflows. However, the Gini coefficient (before government transfers) rose from 0.43 in 2000 to a peak of 0.48 in 2013, before falling to 0.44 in 2023 following redistributive policies. The government's SkillsFuture programme, launched in 2015, provides Singaporeans with credits for skills upgrading, aiming to address structural unemployment arising from technological change and globalisation.

Question: 'Discuss whether Singapore benefits from globalisation.' [10]

Step 1: Introduction

Globalisation refers to the increased integration of national economies through trade in goods and services, capital flows (FDI), technology transfer, and labour migration. Singapore, with a trade-to-GDP ratio exceeding 300% (Extract C) and no natural resources, is structurally dependent on globalisation to a degree that makes autarky not a realistic alternative.

Step 2: Thesis — Singapore DOES benefit

First, globalisation expands Singapore's export markets beyond its domestic market of 5.9 million people. Export revenue drives AD upward, raising real GDP and employment. Extract C shows that real GDP per capita rose from approximately US\$12,000 in 1990 to over US\$65,000 by 2023, a trajectory impossible without global market access. Second, access to cheaper imported inputs lowers firms' production costs, shifting AS rightward — generating disinflationary growth. Third, FDI inflows create employment, transfer technology, and expand productive capacity. Fourth, international competition lowers consumer prices and increases variety, raising consumer surplus.

Step 3: Antithesis — Costs of globalisation

However, globalisation exposes Singapore to external shocks. The economy contracted by 5.4% in 2020 as falling global demand hit export-dependent sectors directly. Structural unemployment arises as labour-intensive manufacturing shifts to lower-cost economies — displaced workers with limited transferable skills face occupational immobility. Extract C shows that income inequality worsened, with the Gini coefficient rising from 0.43 in 2000 to a peak of 0.48 in 2013. High-skilled workers capture a disproportionate share of globalisation's gains, while low-skilled workers face wage competition from foreign labour and automation. Furthermore, Singapore's monetary policy autonomy is constrained by capital mobility under the open-economy trilemma.

Step 4: Evaluation (SPECIES)

The **extent** (E) of Singapore's structural dependence on globalisation is so great that the gains are existential: Singapore cannot feed itself, fuel itself, or sustain its population without trade. The **impact on stakeholders** (I) is uneven (per Extract C): consumers and high-skilled workers benefit most, while low-skilled workers bear the costs. However, the government actively mitigates these costs through SkillsFuture (retraining) and redistributive fiscal policy — the Gini fell from 0.48 to 0.44 after transfers. In the **short run** (S), external shocks cause severe output volatility. In the long run, Singapore's diversification through FTAs such as CPTPP and RCEP reduces dependence on any single market. The **side-effects** (S) of inequality and vulnerability are real but manageable through complementary domestic policies.

Step 5: Judgement

On balance, Singapore **benefits substantially** from globalisation. The growth in GDP per capita from US\$12,000 to US\$65,000 since 1990 (Extract C) would have been unachievable in a closed economy with no natural resources. However, this conclusion holds most strongly because Singapore actively manages the distributional and vulnerability costs through SkillsFuture, Workfare, and FTA diversification. Without these complementary policies, rising inequality (Gini 0.48 at peak) could undermine social cohesion. The conclusion would need significant qualification for larger, self-sufficient economies where the trade-off between gains from trade and external vulnerability is less stark.



Appendix — SPECIES Evaluation by Topic

All 13 H2 Economics Topics (9570)

How to use this appendix: (1) Identify your topic. (2) Check the **Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves** box first — these are the highest-yield evaluation moves. (3) If you need more depth, scan the full SPECIES table for the 2–3 criteria most relevant to the specific question stem. In exam conditions, select 2–3 criteria — do not attempt all seven. The ‘How to write’ column gives a ready-made sentence; adapt it to the specific question context.

Topic 1 The Price Mechanism: Demand, Supply, and Elasticity

Typical stems: ‘Assess the impact of [shock] on [market].’ / ‘Discuss whether a price floor/ceiling achieves its objective.’ / ‘To what extent is [policy] effective in managing price volatility?’



	Criterion	Thesis	Antithesis	How to write	When to use
S	SR vs LR	In the SR, supply is inelastic. A demand shock causes a large price rise with little output adjustment.	In the LR, supply becomes more elastic as firms enter and expand capacity. Price adjusts back toward equilibrium.	“In the short run, the price rise will be large because PES is low. However, in the long run, higher prices attract new entrants, supply shifts rightward, and price falls back.”	Always relevant when a shock hits a market with fixed SR capacity (e.g. agriculture, housing).
P	Priorities	If the priority is low consumer prices, a price ceiling is preferred even at the cost of shortages.	If the priority is producer incomes, a price floor or subsidy is preferred.	“The choice of policy depends on the government’s priority. If consumer welfare is the priority, a price ceiling is preferred. If producer income stability is the priority, a subsidy is more appropriate.”	When evaluating alternative policies targeting the same market.
E	Extent elasticity	If PED and PES are both inelastic, even a small supply disruption causes a large price spike.	If PED is elastic, a price rise significantly reduces quantity demanded, dampening the price increase.	“The magnitude of the price change depends on the elasticity of both demand and supply. With inelastic PED (e.g. essential goods), a supply shock causes a proportionally larger price rise.”	Almost always relevant.
C	Cost	Price controls impose administrative and enforcement costs.	A buffer stock scheme requires large fiscal reserves to buy surplus and sell deficit.	“A buffer stock scheme may be costly to maintain. Storage costs may erode the fiscal benefit over time.”	When evaluating government stabilisation schemes.
I	Impact	A price ceiling benefits consumers (lower prices) but harms producers (reduced revenue, possible exit).	A price floor benefits producers but harms consumers (higher prices, DWL).	“A price ceiling benefits consumers through lower prices but creates allocative inefficiency: producers reduce output, leading to shortages.”	When the question asks about distributional effects.
E	Alternatives	A production subsidy achieves lower consumer prices without creating a shortage.	However, a subsidy imposes a fiscal cost and may encourage overproduction.	“An alternative to a price ceiling is a targeted production subsidy, which raises supply and lowers the equilibrium price without creating a shortage.”	When comparing price ceilings vs subsidies.
S	Side-effects	A price ceiling at below-equilibrium creates a persistent shortage, leading to black markets.	A price floor at above-equilibrium creates a persistent surplus, requiring government purchases.	“A binding price ceiling creates excess demand. Sellers may respond by establishing black markets at prices above the ceiling, eliminating the intended consumer benefit.”	Almost always relevant.

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

- Elasticity-based evaluation:** “The magnitude of the price/quantity effect depends on



PED/PES. Given [evidence], demand/supply is [elastic/inelastic], so the effect will be [large/small].’

2. **SR vs LR market adjustment:** ‘In the SR, supply is inelastic and the price shock is severe. In the LR, market entry restores equilibrium — the key question is whether short-run intervention is warranted given this long-run self-correction mechanism.’
3. **Unintended consequences of price controls:** ‘A binding price ceiling creates excess demand and may generate a black market at a price above the ceiling, reversing the intended consumer benefit entirely.’

Topic 2 Market Failure: Externalities

Typical stems: ‘Assess the effectiveness of a tax/subsidy in correcting [externality].’ / ‘Discuss whether government intervention is justified.’ / ‘Evaluate the most effective policy to correct [negative/positive externality].’



	Criterion	Thesis	Antithesis	How to write	When to use
S	SR vs LR	In the SR, a corrective tax raises prices but quantity may fall only slightly if PED is inelastic.	In the LR, higher prices incentivise firms and consumers to invest in cleaner technology.	“In the short run, the corrective tax is limited by inelastic demand. However, in the long run, the tax incentivises innovation in clean technology, achieving a greater reduction in the externality.”	Essential for any tax/subsidy evaluation.
P	Priorities	If the priority is revenue generation, a Pigouvian tax serves a dual purpose.	If the priority is equity, a regressive tax may conflict with distributional objectives.	“The government’s choice between a tax and direct regulation depends on its priorities. If equity is the priority, a regulation or education campaign avoids the regressive burden.”	When comparing market-based vs non-market policies.
E	Extent of externality	If the MEC is large (e.g. carbon emissions causing irreversible climate damage), intervention is clearly justified.	If the externality is small or uncertain, the administrative cost may exceed the welfare gain.	“Whether intervention is justified depends on the extent of the externality. If the MEC is substantial and the damage irreversible, even an imprecise tax yields a net welfare gain.”	When evaluating whether the government should intervene at all.
C	Cost	A Pigouvian tax generates revenue that can fund further corrective measures.	The government may lack accurate information to set the tax at the precise MEC level.	“A critical constraint is the government’s information problem. Setting the tax equal to MEC requires accurate measurement of external costs, which may be difficult or politically contested.”	Always relevant.
I	Impact	Consumers of the taxed good face higher prices. Third parties benefit.	Third parties benefit; government gains tax revenue.	“The tax redistributes welfare: consumers and producers of the taxed good bear the cost, while third parties and the government gain. Whether this is acceptable depends on relative magnitudes and equity considerations.”	When the question asks who gains and loses.
E	Alternatives	Regulation directly limits the externality and avoids the information problem of setting the correct tax rate.	However, regulation does not internalise the external cost — it removes the price signal and cannot achieve allocative efficiency.	“An alternative to the Pigouvian tax is tradeable pollution permits (cap-and-trade). Permits fix the quantity of emissions and allow the price to be determined by the market, avoiding the information problem.”	When the stem asks ‘most effective policy’.
S	Side-effects	A corrective tax on cigarettes or fuel is regressive — it takes a larger share of income from low-income households.	A ban on a negative externality activity may create a black market.	“The carbon tax, while correcting the externality, imposes a regressive burden. Without targeted transfers (e.g. U-Save rebates in Singapore), the tax worsens income inequality.”	Almost always relevant.



Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Information problem:** ‘The corrective tax requires the government to accurately measure MEC. In practice, MEC is uncertain — if the tax is set below MEC, the market failure is only partially corrected; if above, a new DWL is created.’
2. **LR technology incentive:** ‘In the long run, the Pigouvian tax incentivises firms to invest in cleaner technology, shifting the MPC curve back toward MSC independently of the tax.’
3. **Regressivity + complementary policy:** ‘The tax is regressive. To preserve its corrective function while protecting equity, the government should recycle tax revenue into targeted transfers to low-income households (e.g. Singapore’s U-Save rebates).’

Topic 3 Market Failure: Public Goods and Information Failure

Typical stems: ‘Assess whether the government should directly provide [good/service].’ / ‘Discuss whether information failure justifies government intervention.’ / ‘Evaluate the effectiveness of [labelling/education/regulation] in correcting information asymmetry.’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Nature of the good (Extent):** ‘The appropriateness of direct provision depends on whether the good is a pure public good (non-excludable, non-rivalrous) or merely a merit good with information failure. For the latter, a targeted subsidy or mandatory disclosure may be sufficient and less fiscally burdensome than full direct provision.’
2. **Moral hazard (Side-effects):** ‘A subsidy for health insurance or education may create moral hazard — recipients bear less of the cost and may reduce their own precautionary behaviour, partially undermining the policy objective and generating unintended fiscal costs.’
3. **Fiscal opportunity cost (Cost):** ‘Direct provision requires sustained government expenditure. The opportunity cost of funding [public good] must be weighed against alternative uses of government revenue, such as targeted transfers or supply-side investment.’

Additional SPECIES notes: S (SR: direct provision fills supply gap; LR: may crowd out private innovation) | P (equity priority favours direct provision; fiscal sustainability favours targeted subsidies) | I (direct provision benefits all citizens; subsidies may create moral hazard) | E (public-private partnership as an alternative: preserves private efficiency while guaranteeing public access)

Topic 4 Market Structure: Perfect Competition, Monopoly, Oligopoly

Typical stems: ‘Discuss whether consumers benefit from [market structure/firm behaviour].’ / ‘Assess the impact of a merger on economic efficiency.’ / ‘To what extent does market power harm consumer welfare?’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **SR allocative vs LR dynamic trade-off:** ‘In the short run, market power results in $P > MC$ and DWL, harming consumers. In the long run, supernormal profits fund R&D (dynamic efficiency). The net impact on consumer welfare depends on whether supernormal profits are reinvested — this is the central trade-off in all market structure evaluation.’
2. **Contestability (Extent):** ‘Whether the monopolist’s market power causes significant harm depends on barriers to entry. If the market is contestable (low sunk costs, no IP barriers), the threat of entry disciplines behaviour, and competition policy intervention may be unnecessary.’
3. **Natural monopoly cost trap (Cost):** ‘Breaking up a natural monopoly destroys economies of scale. The resulting higher LRAC may lead to higher, not lower, consumer prices — a price cap or access regulation is a less disruptive and more efficient remedy than forced structural separation.’

Additional SPECIES notes: P (consumer welfare vs international competitiveness: CCCS vs national champion strategy) | I (merger: shareholders gain, consumers harmed by higher prices, rival firms face more powerful competition) | E (price cap regulation vs nationalisation vs structural



break-up) | S (price cap set too aggressively reduces the firm's incentive to invest in capacity and R&D)

Topic 5 National Income, Circular Flow, and the Multiplier

Typical stems: 'Assess whether GDP is a reliable indicator of living standards.' / 'Discuss the impact of [injection/withdrawal] on national income.' / 'To what extent does the multiplier amplify the impact of [fiscal policy]?'

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Singapore multiplier (Extent):** 'The effectiveness of fiscal stimulus in Singapore is fundamentally limited by the small multiplier (~ 0.5 – 0.7). High import leakages (trade-to-GDP $>300\%$) and high CPF savings mean that most injections leak out of the circular flow rapidly, limiting the income-amplification effect significantly.'
2. **GDP vs welfare (Impact):** 'GDP growth does not fully capture improvements in living standards. Distributional effects (Gini coefficient), non-market activities, leisure, and environmental quality are excluded. A rising GDP coexisting with a rising Gini may represent an improvement in aggregate welfare but a deterioration for lower-income groups.'
3. **Fiscal sustainability in Singapore (Cost):** 'Singapore's balanced-budget norm and NIRC framework constrain the government's ability to run sustained deficits. Fiscal expansion is available as a counter-cyclical tool in severe recessions (funded from past reserves) but is not a permanent instrument — this limits the long-run applicability of fiscal policy as a growth driver.'

Additional SPECIES notes: S (SR: multiplier operates over successive rounds; LR: inflationary pressure near full employment) | P (demand-side vs supply-side depending on whether the priority is short-run employment or long-run price stability) | E (MAS exchange rate loosening as alternative to fiscal stimulus in Singapore)

Topic 6 Aggregate Demand and Aggregate Supply (AD/AS)

Typical stems: 'Assess the impact of [shock] on the macroeconomic performance of [economy].' / 'Discuss whether [policy] can simultaneously achieve [two macro objectives].' / 'Evaluate the effectiveness of [demand-side vs supply-side policy].'

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Output gap position (Extent):** 'The effectiveness of AD expansion depends on the current output gap. In the Keynesian range (large negative gap), real output rises significantly with minimal inflation. In the Classical range (near full employment), the same expansion is primarily inflationary — this is the most important contextual variable for any AD policy question.'
2. **LR neutrality of AD policy:** 'In the long run, AD policy is neutral in real terms — wages and costs adjust, SRAS shifts left, and output returns to LRAS. The permanent effect of AD expansion is a higher price level, not higher real output. Only AS-side policies can permanently raise the full-employment output level.'
3. **Singapore: MAS vs fiscal (Alternatives):** 'Singapore's primary counter-cyclical tool is the MAS exchange rate, not fiscal policy. The small multiplier (0.5 – 0.7) and balanced-budget norm limit fiscal effectiveness. Exchange rate adjustment acts faster and avoids a fiscal deficit, but creates a competitiveness trade-off for exporters.'

Additional SPECIES notes: S (SR: output rises along SRAS; LR: SRAS shifts left back to LRAS) | P (demand-side vs supply-side depending on priority: short-run employment or long-run price stability) | C (supply-side policies have long gestation periods and high upfront costs) | S (demand-pull inflation if economy nears full capacity)



Topic 7 Unemployment

Typical stems: ‘Assess the effectiveness of [policy] in reducing unemployment.’ / ‘Discuss whether demand-side or supply-side policy is more appropriate.’ / ‘To what extent can the government reduce structural unemployment?’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Type of unemployment determines the policy (Extent):** ‘Cyclical unemployment responds to AD expansion. Structural unemployment does not — it requires supply-side retraining and education reform. Applying demand-side policy to structural unemployment is ineffective because it raises output without resolving the underlying skills mismatch.’
2. **Supply-side time lag (SR vs LR):** ‘Supply-side policies (SkillsFuture, education reform) address structural unemployment at the root but have long gestation periods — 5 to 10 years for retraining programmes to produce measurable changes in the skill composition of the workforce. In the short run, displaced workers need income support (Workfare, JSS) alongside retraining.’
3. **Singapore: structural unemployment hidden in low headline rate (Impact):** ‘Singapore’s headline unemployment rate (~2%) understates structural displacement. A significant share of the workforce may be underemployed. Workfare and Progressive Wage Model policies address the welfare of low-wage workers but do not resolve the underlying structural skills gap.’

Additional SPECIES notes: P (rapid employment recovery → AD expansion; long-run labour productivity → supply-side reform) | C (retraining is individually and socially costly with uncertain outcomes) | E (immigration via Employment Pass scheme fills short-run structural gaps faster than domestic retraining, but may depress wages for local mid-skilled workers) | S (wage subsidies may create structural rigidities by slowing labour market adjustment)

Topic 8 Inflation and Deflation

Typical stems: ‘Assess the effectiveness of MAS’s exchange rate policy in managing inflation.’ / ‘Discuss whether demand-pull/cost-push inflation requires different policy responses.’ / ‘To what extent is deflation harmful?’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Source of inflation determines policy (Extent):** ‘Demand-pull inflation responds to AD tightening (MAS appreciation). Cost-push inflation from external sources is less responsive — if global commodity prices rise across all currencies simultaneously, exchange rate appreciation reduces but cannot eliminate the cost shock. Complementary fiscal transfers are needed to protect vulnerable households.’
2. **MAS exchange rate trade-off (Cost):** ‘MAS’s SGD appreciation reduces imported inflation but raises export prices, reducing export competitiveness. This trade-off is inherent in Singapore’s exchange-rate-centred monetary framework — lower inflation and export competitiveness cannot be simultaneously maximised.’
3. **Deflation risk (Side-effects):** ‘Deflationary expectations are self-fulfilling and extremely difficult to reverse. Once households and firms expect prices to fall, deferred consumption and investment accelerate the deflation. The asymmetry between mild inflation (manageable) and deflation (potentially catastrophic) justifies a preference for a small positive inflation target.’

Additional SPECIES notes: S (SR: demand-pull inflation can be reduced by tightening AD; cost-push inflation is harder because tightening AD worsens the output contraction; LR: entrenched inflation expectations raise the cost of disinflation) | P (price stability vs employment and output; MAS faces a priority trade-off between steeper slope and export competitiveness) | I (fixed-income households bear the greatest burden from inflation; debtors benefit; homeowners with mortgages benefit from inflation)



Topic 9 Economic Growth

Typical stems: ‘Assess the effectiveness of [supply-side policy] in promoting economic growth.’ / ‘Discuss the costs and benefits of economic growth.’ / ‘To what extent can [economy] achieve sustainable and inclusive growth?’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Actual vs potential growth (SR vs LR):** ‘Short-run growth from AD expansion closes the output gap without raising productive capacity — it is inherently limited and inflationary near full employment. Only supply-side policies that shift LRAS rightward generate sustainable potential growth. Singapore, near full employment, must focus on the latter.’
2. **Productivity imperative (Extent):** ‘Singapore’s economy is near full employment, meaning factor accumulation is largely exhausted as a growth driver. Continued growth requires total factor productivity (TFP) improvement — shifting from input-driven to innovation-driven growth. This makes supply-side policies (R&D investment, SkillsFuture, RIE plans) the primary growth tool.’
3. **Inclusive growth trade-off (Priorities):** ‘Maximising aggregate growth rate and ensuring inclusive growth are not always compatible. Skill-biased technological change concentrates gains among high-skill workers. Complementary redistributive policies (Progressive Wage Model, Workfare) are necessary to ensure that growth benefits lower-income groups and maintains social cohesion.’

Additional SPECIES notes: C (rapid industrialisation may generate environmental degradation; Singapore’s carbon tax trajectory rising to S\$50–80/tonne by 2030 reflects the government’s recognition that sustainable growth requires internalising environmental costs) | I (growth has raised average incomes substantially but the Gini coefficient has fluctuated, suggesting gains have not been evenly distributed) | E (FDI-led growth vs innovation-led growth; Singapore’s RIE plans reflect the strategic shift toward domestic R&D)

Topic 10 Balance of Payments (BOP)

Typical stems: ‘Assess the effectiveness of [policy] in correcting a current account deficit.’ / ‘Discuss whether a current account surplus is beneficial.’ / ‘To what extent can exchange rate depreciation improve the current account?’

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **J-curve + Marshall-Lerner (SR vs LR):** ‘Depreciation worsens the current account in the short run (J-curve effect) before improving it in the long run — but only if the Marshall-Lerner condition is satisfied ($PED_x + PED_m > 1$). If demand for exports and imports is inelastic, the long-run improvement may also be insufficient to correct the deficit.’
2. **Cyclical vs structural deficit (Extent):** ‘The appropriate policy response depends on whether the current account deficit is cyclical or structural. A cyclical deficit self-corrects as the economic cycle turns. A structural deficit requires supply-side reform of export competitiveness — exchange rate adjustment addresses the price but not the underlying productivity gap.’
3. **Singapore depreciation cost (Cost):** ‘A deliberate SGD depreciation to boost exports would generate significant cost-push inflation in Singapore, which imports virtually all of its energy, food, and industrial inputs. This imported inflation cost — borne by all households — may outweigh the export competitiveness gain, explaining why MAS consistently chooses appreciation over depreciation.’

Additional SPECIES notes: P (reducing the current account deficit via expenditure-reducing policies would lower import demand but also reduce domestic output and employment; if employment is the priority, structural supply-side measures are preferred) | I (weak exchange rate benefits export-oriented firms and workers; harms domestic consumers paying higher import prices) | E (supply-side export promotion — improving product quality, moving up the value chain — raises export competitiveness without importing inflation) | S (persistent depreciation may trigger retaliatory currency depreciation by trading partners)



Topic 11 Exchange Rates and Monetary Policy (Singapore Context)

Typical stems: 'Assess the effectiveness of MAS's exchange rate policy in achieving Singapore's macroeconomic objectives.' / 'Discuss the trade-offs in Singapore's choice of exchange rate regime.' / 'Evaluate whether a stronger or weaker SGD is beneficial.'

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Trilemma constraint (Cost):** 'Singapore's exchange-rate-centred monetary policy reflects a trilemma choice: free capital mobility and a managed SGD NEER are retained, but interest rate autonomy is sacrificed. Domestic rates follow global rates. This means all monetary adjustment must be delivered through the exchange rate — Singapore cannot use independent interest rate cuts or hikes as a counter-cyclical tool.'
2. **Appreciation trade-off (SR vs LR):** 'SGD appreciation reduces imported inflation in the short run (high pass-through given trade-to-GDP >300%). In the long run, persistent appreciation erodes export price competitiveness — manufacturing firms face pressure to relocate. Singapore's response has been to maintain competitiveness through productivity growth (non-price channel) rather than exchange rate depreciation.'
3. **MAS slope/width/centre mechanism (Priorities):** 'MAS adjusts three parameters of the SGD NEER policy band: the slope (rate of appreciation), width (tolerance band), and centre (re-centring to market rate). Steeper slope = tighter stance (anti-inflation); flatter slope or re-centring downward = looser stance (pro-growth). Evaluation must connect the specific parameter change to the macroeconomic objective being targeted.'

Additional SPECIES notes: E (Singapore's exceptional openness — trade-to-GDP >300% — means exchange rate movements have an unusually large effect on the domestic price level; high pass-through coefficient makes the exchange rate an effective anti-inflation tool) | I (appreciation benefits consumers and import-dependent firms; harms export-oriented firms and manufacturing workers) | S (rapid SGD appreciation carries the risk of overshooting; if appreciation is too aggressive, deflationary expectations may emerge)

Topic 12 International Trade, Comparative Advantage, and Protectionism

Typical stems: 'Discuss whether free trade is beneficial for [economy].' / 'Assess the case for protectionism in [industry/country].' / 'Evaluate whether [tariff/quota/subsidy] is justified.' / 'To what extent does comparative advantage explain [trade pattern]?''

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **SR structural adjustment vs LR gains (SR vs LR):** 'Trade liberalisation generates net welfare gains in the long run but creates structural adjustment costs in the short run. Displaced workers in import-competing industries bear a concentrated short-run cost, while the long-run gains are diffuse. The policy question is whether the government can manage the transition — through retraining and income support — to make the adjustment politically and socially acceptable.'
2. **Tariff vs subsidy efficiency (Alternatives):** 'A production subsidy is more efficient than a tariff for supporting a domestic industry: it raises domestic output without distorting consumer prices, avoiding the consumption DWL. However, the subsidy imposes a direct fiscal cost. The choice between them reflects the government's trade-off between efficiency and fiscal impact.'
3. **Infant industry credibility problem (Side-effects):** 'The infant industry argument for temporary tariff protection has a fundamental credibility flaw: governments cannot credibly commit to removing the tariff once the industry matures, because the protected producers will lobby to retain it. Temporary protection tends to become permanent, perpetuating the inefficiency it was meant to solve.'

Additional SPECIES notes: E (comparative advantage is not fixed — Singapore has no natural resources but has developed comparative advantage in financial services, precision manufacturing,



and logistics through deliberate policy choices) | C (welfare cost of a tariff includes a consumption DWL and a production DWL, both borne by domestic consumers; risk of retaliatory tariffs adds a second-order cost) | I (tariff imposition: domestic producers in the protected sector gain; domestic consumers lose; government gains tariff revenue; net welfare effect is negative)

Topic 13 Globalisation and the Open Economy

Typical stems: 'Discuss whether Singapore benefits from globalisation.' / 'Assess the impact of FDI on a host economy.' / 'Evaluate whether globalisation increases or decreases income inequality.' / 'Discuss the costs and benefits of economic integration.'

Top 3 Exam-Ready Moves

1. **Existential dependence (Extent):** 'For Singapore, the evaluation of globalisation is not a trade-off between openness and autarky — autarky is simply not viable for a resource-scarce island of 5.9 million. The relevant question is whether globalisation is well-managed: whether the gains are broadly shared and the vulnerabilities actively mitigated through FTA diversification, reserves accumulation, and domestic redistributive policies.'
2. **Differential stakeholder impact (Impact):** 'Globalisation benefits consumers (lower prices, greater variety) and high-skilled workers (high wages for globally demanded skills) disproportionately. Low-skilled workers bear the cost through wage competition and structural displacement. Singapore's Workfare, Progressive Wage Model, and SkillsFuture reflect recognition that openness requires active management of distributional consequences.'
3. **FDI enclave risk (Side-effects):** 'FDI generates employment and technology transfer, but the depth of benefit depends on backward linkages to local firms. If MNCs source globally rather than locally, technology spillovers to domestic firms are limited. The policy challenge is to deepen local supply chain integration (EDB's LEAD programme) to ensure FDI benefits permeate the broader economy.'

Additional SPECIES notes: S (SR: trade and FDI flows raise AD; LR: globalisation raises productive capacity through technology transfer and specialisation, but also creates structural unemployment as industries are displaced) | P (Singapore's open economy strategy deliberately prioritises aggregate growth and allocative efficiency from trade specialisation; equity concerns addressed through complementary domestic policies) | C (dependence on global demand and capital flows exposes the economy to external shocks; Singapore's 2020 GDP contraction of 5.4% illustrates this vulnerability)

End of Document

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